Asma Masacal Alauya Panda

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Atty. Asma Masacal Alauya Panda is a Maranao legal scholar, financial regulator, and pioneering woman in Philippine central banking. She serves as the **Senior Director and Deputy General Counsel** of the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas (BSP), making her the first woman, first Muslim, and first Maranao to hold this position in the institution's history. Over a 22-year career with the BSP, Panda has authored the legal frameworks for landmark financial modernization legislation, including the Islamic Banking Law (Republic Act No. 11439), which established Shari'ah-compliant banking regulation across the Philippines and significantly advanced financial inclusion for Bangsamoro and Muslim Filipino communities.

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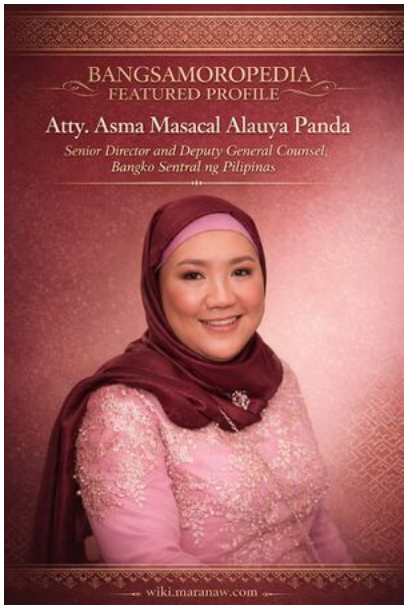
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Early Life and Lineage

Asma Masacal Alauya was born into one of Lanao del Sur's most distinguished families of legal scholarship and public service. Her father, **Atty. Saaduddin A. Alauya, Sr.**, was a seminal figure in Philippine Islamic jurisprudence, serving as a Jurisconsult in Islamic Law and as the Vice-Governor of Lanao del Sur. Her mother, **Hadja Maimuna Masacal Alauya**, held the traditional Maranao title of *Bai sa Bayabao*, signifying her status as a respected community leader and keeper of cultural heritage.

The Alauya household was one where law, faith, and public service were interwoven into daily life. This foundation would profoundly shape Asma's professional identity and her later commitment to bridging Islamic principles with financial governance.

Her siblings have similarly pursued institutional leadership across finance, education, medicine, and Islamic law. **Arifa Alauya-Ala** serves as Senior Assistant Governor at the BSP, where she has become a leading figure in Islamic finance regulation and central bank operations. **Saaduddin M. Alauya, Jr.** holds the position of Vice Chancellor at Mindanao State University. **Dr. Aslama Alauya-Lamping** is a medical professional. **Aninding M. Alauya** practices as a Shari'ah Lawyer. This constellation of achievement across sectors reflects not privilege alone, but a family ethos of meritocratic excellence and service.



Asma Masacal Alauya Panda	
Position	Senior Director and Deputy General Counsel, Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Birth Name	Asma Masacal Alauya
Spouse	Cairoden C. Panda
Children	Amal Jayieda A. Panda, Anon Jarya Panda
Education	Mindanao State University (B.S. Business Administration, B.L.), New York University (LL.M. Corporate Law)
Employer	Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas (2002–present)
Known For	Islamic Banking Law, Financial modernization legislation, Institutional diversity in central banking

Education

Panda's academic record at Mindanao State University established her as an exceptional scholar in two distinct fields. She earned her **Bachelor of Science in Business Administration** with a specialization in Management, graduating *Magna Cum Laude*. Recognizing her analytical strengths, she subsequently pursued legal studies at the same institution.

In the College of Law, she distinguished herself further, graduating *Cum Laude* and earning the honor of **Class Valedictorian**. Her dual expertise in business administration and law would later prove invaluable in navigating the complexities of central bank governance, where technical regulatory acumen must align with institutional finance.

Her postgraduate trajectory took her to the United States. As a **BSP BEST Scholar** (a competitive fellowship for promising civil servants), she was selected to pursue advanced legal studies at New York University. There, she earned her **Master of Laws (LL.M.) in Corporate Law**, a specialization that positioned her to grapple with the intricate legal structures underlying modern financial regulation and central bank operations.

Professional Career

Early Years at the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas

Panda joined the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas in 2002 as a junior lawyer in the Office of the General Counsel and Legal Services (OGCLS). At that time, the BSP's legal function was primarily reactive, focused on contract review and institutional defense. Over the subsequent two decades, the role of the General Counsel's office would transform dramatically as the Philippine financial system itself underwent modernization.

She rose through the ranks of the OGCLS with steady recognition for her technical precision, cultural insight, and capacity to translate complex financial and regulatory concepts into coherent legal frameworks. Her peers recalled her as intellectually rigorous, culturally grounded, and unafraid to ask difficult questions when ambiguity arose.

Deputy General Counsel and Senior Director

In 2019, Panda was promoted to **Deputy General Counsel**, and her title was later elevated to **Senior Director** in recognition of her strategic scope. As the second-most senior lawyer in the institution, she oversaw major legal policy initiatives, advised the Governor's office on regulatory matters, and coordinated the bank's litigation and compliance functions.

Her technical purview expanded to include monetary policy law, banking regulation, financial crime prevention, payment systems law, and—most significantly—Islamic finance regulation. She became the institutional authority on the legal frameworks governing Bangsamoro-Muslim financial participation in the Philippine banking system.

In a temporary designation, Panda also served as **Chief of Staff to the Governor of the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas**, placing her at the strategic center of the institution's administrative decision-making. However, in interviews and institutional communications, she has consistently expressed her preference for the disciplined, detail-oriented work of legal drafting and regulatory analysis over administrative management. This choice reflected her core conviction that law, when precisely crafted, is the most powerful instrument for institutional integrity.

Legislative Architecture

Panda's most consequential contributions to Philippine governance lie in her role as a primary legal architect of five landmark pieces of financial legislation that have fundamentally reshaped the banking and payment systems landscape.

The Islamic Banking Law (Republic Act No. 11439)

The passage of the **Islamic Banking Law** in 2019 represented a historic milestone in financial inclusion. For decades, the Philippine financial system was structured around conventional interest-based banking, which is prohibited under Shari'ah law. This created a structural barrier to Bangsamoro and Muslim Filipino participation in the formal financial system, effectively excluding millions of citizens from credit, savings products, and investment opportunities.

Panda served as the principal legal author of the statutory framework governing Shari'ah-compliant banking institutions. The law established a specialized regulatory regime allowing banks to offer Islamic banking services (*murabaha*, *musharaka*, *ijarah*, and other Shari'ah instruments) alongside conventional banking. It also created the Islamic Banking Supervisory Board and outlined prudential standards specific to Islamic financial products.

More than a technical achievement, this law represented cultural recognition. As Panda herself has noted in institutional settings, Islamic banking regulation was not merely a financial inclusion tool, it was a statement that the Philippine banking system could accommodate the ethical and religious obligations of its Muslim citizens without compromise. The law has since enabled the establishment of multiple Islamic banking windows and, in 2023, the establishment of the first fully-fledged Islamic bank in the Philippines.

Amendments to the New Central Bank Act (Republic Act No. 11211)

In 2018, the **New Central Bank Act** underwent substantial amendment to modernize the BSP's institutional architecture and expand its powers. Panda contributed to the legal framework for several key amendments, including provisions that increased the BSP's statutory capital to 200 billion pesos (from 50 billion) and expanded its corporate governance and supervisory authorities over non-bank financial institutions.

These amendments reflected a global consensus (post-2008 financial crisis) that central banks required broader prudential authority to manage systemic financial risk. Panda's contribution ensured that the Philippine amendments aligned with international best practices while respecting the nation's constitutional constraints on central bank authority.

The National Payment Systems Act (Republic Act No. 11127)

The **National Payment Systems Act** of 2018 established the first comprehensive statutory framework governing payment system operators, clearing houses, and settlement systems in the Philippines. Panda's contributions to its legal drafting ensured that the act addressed emerging risks in digital payments and fintech while preserving the stability and interoperability of the nation's payment infrastructure.

The law was enacted at a moment of rapid fintech innovation, where unregulated digital payment platforms threatened both consumer protection and systemic stability. The statute created clearer boundaries around what constitutes a payment system operator, defined settlement obligations, and empowered the BSP to establish prudential standards and technical requirements.

The FIST Act (Republic Act No. 11523)

During the COVID-19 pandemic, the Philippine financial system faced unprecedented stress as borrowers struggled to service debts. The **Financial Institutions Strategic Transfer (FIST) Act** of 2020 provided a legal framework allowing banks to transfer non-performing assets (NPAs) to Asset Management Corporations (AMCs) at a faster pace, without triggering immediate loss recognition that would impair bank capital.

This technical legal mechanism was critical to the financial system's ability to absorb pandemic-related distress without triggering a credit crunch. Panda's role in drafting the statutory mechanics of NPA transfer, pricing methodologies, and the legal status of transferred assets was essential to the law's effectiveness.

The Agri-Fisheries Financing Enhancement Act (Republic Act No. 11901)

The **Agri-Fisheries Financing Enhancement Act** of 2022 aimed to expand credit access for agricultural, fisheries, and rural development sectors, which have historically faced credit constraints. Panda contributed to its legal framework, which simplified collateral requirements for farm and fishery loans and incentivized lending to underserved rural communities.

This legislation reflected a broader policy aim: ensuring that financial modernization benefited not only urban and formal sector participants but also the agricultural and fishing communities that form the backbone of Philippine food security.

Cultural Significance and Role in Bangsamoro Governance

Panda's presence in the senior executive leadership of the BSP carries significance that extends beyond technical legal achievement. She represents a cultural breakthrough in Philippine institutional governance, one that did not occur through tokenism or symbolic gesture, but through 22 years of meritocratic advancement and demonstrated technical mastery.

In the context of Bangsamoro governance, her prominence signals something profound: that the highest levels of Philippine financial administration are not closed to Muslims or Maranao professionals. When she championed the Islamic Banking Law, she was not merely advancing an economic policy; she was translating the financial ethical requirements of her faith into a statutory framework that enables her community's economic participation. This is bridge-building at the most fundamental level, because it operates not through rhetoric but through the mechanics of law and regulation.

Her father's legacy as a Jurisconsult in Islamic Law had provided the intellectual foundation; Asma's career has extended that legacy into the sphere of modern financial governance. In doing so, she has demonstrated that Islamic jurisprudence and contemporary central banking are not incompatible domains, but can be harmonized through careful legal craft.

Personal Life

Panda is married to **Cairoden C. Panda**. The couple has two daughters who have continued the family's tradition of academic and professional distinction.

Amal Jayieda A. Panda is a dual-qualified professional, holding credentials as both a **Certified Public Accountant (CPA)** and a practicing **Lawyer**. Her dual expertise positions her for careers spanning financial auditing, corporate advisory, or financial law.

Anon Jarya Panda continues the family's commitment to higher education and professional achievement.

Legacy and Recognition

Atty. Asma Masacal Alauya Panda's career embodies a rare combination of attributes: intellectual rigor, technical mastery, institutional loyalty, and cultural consciousness. She has been a bridge between traditional Maranao values and modern Philippine governance, demonstrating that these are not opposing forces but complementary dimensions of a complete professional identity.

Her legislative contributions have reshaped the Philippine financial landscape in ways that will outlast her tenure at the BSP. The Islamic Banking Law, in particular, is likely to be remembered as a turning point in financial inclusion and the recognition of minority religious communities within the formal economy.

Her ascent to one of the most senior legal positions in the nation's central bank stands as a quiet but unmistakable statement about the capacity of Philippine institutions to recognize excellence regardless of gender, religious identity, or regional origin. She has not merely broken a glass ceiling; she has built institutions that will be more inclusive because she has held them.

See Also

- Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas
- Islamic Banking Law (Republic Act No. 11439)
- Financial Regulation in the Philippines
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Maranao people
- Islamic finance in the Philippines

References

External Links

- Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas Official Website (https://www.bsp.gov.ph)
- BangsamoroPedia (https://www.bangsamoropedia.org)

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